

Business Debt & Credit Help

Struggling with business debt, or trying to build business credit? You can get out of trouble and set your business up to borrow on good terms. Below are trusted national resources. Tick the box once you've checked each one.

⚠ BEFORE YOU START

Business debt has different rules than personal debt, and good business credit saves you money for years. Watch out for "debt settlement" firms charging big fees — the free and low-cost help below is safer.

1 Get Free Debt Advice

Trusted advisors help you build a plan to handle business debt.

☐ SCORE & SBDC — Free Counseling

Free mentors help you restructure debt, cut costs, and plan a path forward.

→ www.score.org

☐ SBA — Manage Your Finances

SBA guidance on managing cash flow and debt.

→ www.sba.gov/business-guide/manage-your-business/manage-your-finances

2 Build Business Credit

Strong business credit means better loans and terms down the road.

☐ Get an EIN & Separate Accounts

Use a business EIN and bank account to start building credit separate from your personal credit.

→ www.irs.gov/businesses/small-businesses-self-employed/apply-for-an-employer-identification-number-ein-online

☐ Understand Business Credit Scores

Learn how business credit works and how to build it (Dun & Bradstreet D-U-N-S number is free).

→ www.dnb.com/duns/get-a-duns.html

3 Handle Trouble the Right Way

If debt is overwhelming, know your real options.

☐ CFPB — Small Business Protections

Know your rights with lenders and debt collectors.

→ www.consumerfinance.gov/consumer-tools/debt-collection

☐ Refinance With a Safer Lender

A CDFI or SBA loan may replace high-cost debt with affordable terms.

→ www.cdfifund.gov/programs-training/certification/cdfi

4 Avoid Debt Traps

Some “quick cash” products dig businesses deeper into trouble.

☐ Watch Out for Merchant Cash Advances

These high-cost advances can trap your business. A free advisor can help you find safer options.

→ www.score.org

⚠ WATCH OUT FOR

Avoid “business debt relief” companies that charge large upfront fees or tell you to stop paying creditors. And steer clear of merchant cash advances with daily withdrawals — their true cost is enormous.

★ A TIP THAT HELPS

Keep business and personal finances separate from day one — it protects you legally and builds business credit, so you qualify for better loans without risking your personal assets.

NEED HELP WHERE YOU LIVE?

Need help where you live?

This guide covers national resources. For local debt counseling and safe lenders in your area, use the personalized AI search or ask in the Questions area.

MY NOTES — WHO I CALLED, WHEN, AND WHAT THEY SAID
